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Highland plateau Amhara of Ethiopia

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6.2.1.4 Social aspects of the zar cult

The groups of chronically possessed persons who meet regularly as devotees of the zars in the wedaja constitute what are called ak'k'wada[unknown]s (sometimes ak't'ac'c'a), face-to face societies. Their interpersonal relationships soon become social, much like the mehaber communal worship society of the church. Both establish bonds of "artificial kinship". Not infrequently this leads to the establishment of bonds of actual affinal kinship (as described earlier).

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The parallel can also be applied to an understanding of the leadership involved. Much like the mehaber is led and blessed by the priest-confessor, so the zar society is led and blessed by the zar doctor, preferably a woman like Weyzero Selemteaw. The zar complex, in Amhara society, represents the shadow side of the visible human world, making it complete. Hence, just as the Christian (and also the Muslim) religion emphasizes the male-dominated, patriarchal side of society, so does the zar complex represent the obverse, the female-dominated, matriarchal side of society.

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This is further reinforced by the subordinate socio-psychological position of the Amhara woman. She may not enter the church. Her daily labors are largely limited to routine, manual, monotonous tasks. Only noblewomen are exempt from this social position of the "commoner" female, and therefore are not

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found in the zar cult - which therefore has a lower-class connotation in the basically two-class Amhara society.

Socially undistinguished, "commoner" Amhara women who chafe under their social inferiority, including women of potential talent repressed in their culture, are likely to develop ailments such as melancholia, apathy, catatonic states, migraine, or hysteria. Thus the zar doctor is called in and the patient enters the zar society.

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The socio-psychological improvement, even apart from medical considerations, which the woman experiences as member of a zar-devotee society, is considerable. Once her individual zar has been diagnosed, she has acquired an individual "self" which is respected, acknowledged, at first within, and finally even outside the zar society. Thus the zar society emphasizes individualism, free expression, individual enterprise, as against the outside Amhara world which suppresses it in commoners, especially in the Amhara women. The business enterprise of the female zar doctor and many devotees has already been described.

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Some women with hysterical tendencies revert to infantile behavior. In the zar society they can act this out, while protected and disciplined by the matriarchal zar doctor. Others, with a father-complex, join zar societies headed by male zar doctors. In either case they enjoy recreation and amusement with the "sibling" devotees, with whom they can gossip and enact sibling jokes, such as playfully accusing each other of minor oversights in the service of the zar (it often takes this form).

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Even her life outside the zar society becomes changed. She is now considered as guided by a protective zar who can  324 extend his protection to other members of the family. Her husband, even if he objects to the zar, often will admit the radiant beauty of her face and her bearing, due to the wiqabi (protective zar). As a result of her exposure to businesswomen, the menfolk in her family will not shunt her aside when talking business, or legal or kin matters. Some women devotees whose bent is more feminine, become midwives, "experts" in domestic obstetrics and primitive gynecology. There are many ways in which the woman's social status improves. No longer is she a mere hauler of water and hewer of wood. This change usually relieves her mental ailment - and this cure is ascribed to the zar doctors and the zar complex, even as cures are ascribed to religious cults and psychiatrists in western society.

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